

Ancient Egyptian priests and other magicians had a variety of strategies for thwarting malevolent deities. In the spells themselves they might claim authority over the deity by uttering its name; or trick a demon into believing it was attacking the goddess Isis and her child Horus rather than a humble mother and baby; or threaten the god with the wrath of an even more terrible power, such as Seth, the murderous deity of the desert and of disorder. Protective spells were written on papyri and worn on the body or hidden in containers as amulets.

Magical inscriptions might be written on bowls and the person seeking protection would drink water from these. Cippi (carved slabs) showing Horus defeating dangerous animals such as snakes were placed in rooms to prevent and cure stings and bites.

Cursing enemies

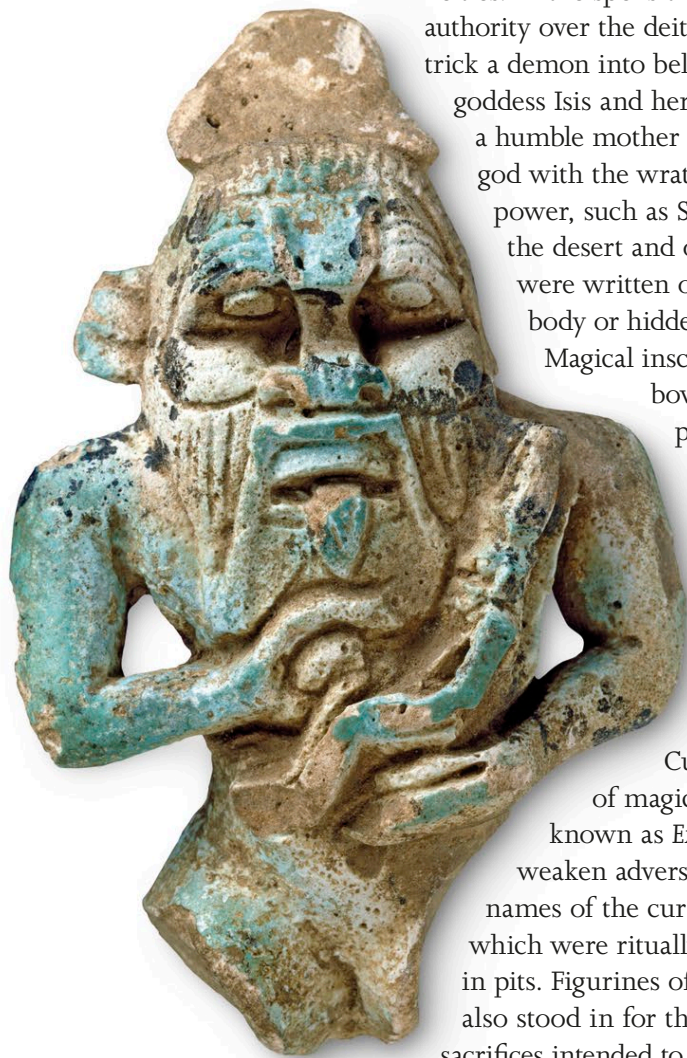
Curses were a specialized form of magic. Contained in collections known as *Execration Texts*, they sought to weaken adversaries through magic. The names of the cursed were written on pots, which were ritually smashed and deposited in pits. Figurines of bound men and women also stood in for the real targets in ritual sacrifices intended to deny the victims an afterlife. However, people left in limbo between this life and the next could become *mut* (the troublesome dead who would seek revenge on the living).

One curse calls for the practitioner to cut hair from a corpse and tie it to that of a living person, who would then be driven mad. Another orders a curse papyrus to be attached to an iron ring and



▲ Paper magic

This section of the *London Medical Papyrus*, composed around 1300 BCE, includes around 60 medical and magical remedies for a range of diseases, particularly of the eye, and for burns and gynecological conditions.



▲ Invoking protection

The lion-dwarf god Bes was a popular protector god. His hideous face was believed to scare off demons. He was most often called on during childbirth, and in this amulet he cradles the infant Horus.

buried in a grave. The papyrus would bind the deceased forever to the tomb. Curses written within tombs themselves warned trespassers against desecrating the burial chamber on pain of eternal suffering. This practice was more common during the Old Kingdom (2575–2150 BCE) as burials, including those within pyramids, became more elaborate and the grave goods they contained more attractive to robbers.

Medicine and magic

The line between medicine and magic was blurred in ancient Egypt, and priests of Sekhmet often also acted as doctors. In the absence of effective remedies to cure many ailments, they turned to spells and rituals. Some magic was “sympathetic,”

“As for any person, scribe, any wise man, any commoner, or any inferior, who will do evil in this tomb ... they will submit to the wrath of Thoth.”

CURSE FROM TOMB OF DJEFAYHAPY, c. 1900 BCE